DEFENCE JOURNEY

CDS General Knowledge Notes

History, Geography, Polity, Economy, Science and Defence for the CDS GK paper

CDS | GK

The CDS General Knowledge paper has **100 questions for 100 marks** in 2 hours (1/3 negative marking). It covers History, Geography, Polity, Economy, General Science and Current Affairs. These notes give the key facts for each. Questions on Current Affairs depend on the latest 12 months, so follow a newspaper daily and add those facts to your own notebook.

Subject	Approx. weight	Focus
History (with freedom movement)	~20%	Modern India, Medieval, Ancient basics
Geography	~20%	India (rivers, climate, resources) and basic world geography
Polity	~15 to 20%	Constitution, Parliament, rights, bodies
Economy	~10 to 15%	Banking, budget, inflation, basic terms
General Science	~15%	Physics, Chemistry and Biology (NCERT level)
Current Affairs	~10 to 15%	Last 12 months, defence, sports, awards

REMEMBER: Facts that depend on current office-holders or recent events change with time. Verify them from a newspaper or an official site before your exam.

A. HISTORY

Ancient and Medieval India (quick facts)

- **Indus Valley Civilisation** (about 2600 to 1900 BCE): Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Lothal (dockyard), Dholavira, Kalibangan. Well-planned cities with drainage.
- **Buddha** was born at Lumbini, got enlightenment at Bodh Gaya, gave his first sermon at Sarnath and died at Kushinagar. **Mahavira** was the 24th Tirthankara of Jainism.
- **Mauryan Empire** (321 BCE): Chandragupta Maurya, Bindusara, **Ashoka** (Kalinga war 261 BCE, Dhamma). Arthashastra: Kautilya. **Gupta Age** (320 CE): Samudragupta, Chandragupta II, Kalidasa, Aryabhata, Fa-Hien. **Harsha**: Hiuen Tsang visited.
- **Cholas:** Rajaraja I (Brihadeeswara temple, Thanjavur), Rajendra I (strong navy).
- **Delhi Sultanate (1206 to 1526):** Slave, Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid, Lodi. Qutb-ud-din Aibak (Qutub Minar), Iltutmish, Razia Sultana, Alauddin Khalji (market reforms), Muhammad bin Tughlaq (capital shifted to Daulatabad, token currency), Firoz Shah Tughlaq.
- **Mughals:** Babur (First Battle of Panipat 1526), Humayun, Sher Shah Suri (Grand Trunk Road, rupee), Akbar (Second Panipat 1556, Din-i-Ilahi, Mansabdari), Jahangir, Shah Jahan (Taj Mahal, Red Fort), Aurangzeb (d. 1707).

- **Vijayanagara** (1336): Krishnadevaraya (Hampi). **Marathas:** Shivaji (crowned at Raigad, 1674). Third Battle of Panipat (1761).
- **Bhakti and Sufi saints:** Kabir, Guru Nanak, Mirabai, Tulsidas, Chaitanya, Ramananda; Khwaja Moinuddin Chishti, Nizamuddin Auliya.

Modern India: Key Dates

Year	Event	Year	Event
1757	Battle of Plassey (Clive vs Siraj-ud-Daulah)	1929	Lahore Congress, Purna Swaraj demand
1764	Battle of Buxar	1930	Civil Disobedience; Dandi March (12 March)
1829	Sati abolished (Bentinck)	1931	Gandhi-Irwin Pact
1857	Revolt of 1857 (began at Meerut, 10 May)	1932	Poona Pact
1858	Rule passes to the British Crown	1935	Government of India Act
1885	Indian National Congress founded	1942	Cripps Mission; Quit India (8 Aug)
1905	Partition of Bengal (Curzon)	1943	INA, Provisional Government (Bose)
1906	Muslim League founded	1946	Cabinet Mission
1916	Lucknow Pact; Home Rule Leagues	1947	Independence, 15 August
1919	Rowlatt Act, Jallianwala Bagh (13 April)	1948	Gandhiji assassinated (30 Jan)
1920 to 22	Non-Cooperation; Chauri Chaura	1950	Constitution in force, 26 Jan

- **Governors-General and Viceroys:** Warren Hastings (first Governor of Bengal), Lord Cornwallis (Permanent Settlement 1793), Wellesley (Subsidiary Alliance), Bentinck (reforms), Dalhousie (Doctrine of Lapse, railways, telegraph), Canning (first Viceroy, 1858), Curzon (Bengal partition 1905), Hardinge (capital moved to Delhi 1911), Mountbatten (last Viceroy and first Governor-General of free India), C. Rajagopalachari (last Governor-General).
- **Reformers:** Raja Ram Mohan Roy (Brahmo Samaj, 1828), Dayananda Saraswati (Arya Samaj, 1875), Swami Vivekananda (Ramakrishna Mission, 1897), Jyotiba Phule (Satyashodhak Samaj), Sir Syed Ahmad Khan (Aligarh Movement), Vidyasagar (widow remarriage).
- **Leaders:** Gandhi, Nehru, Sardar Patel (Iron Man), Subhas Chandra Bose (Netaji), Tilak ("Swaraj is my birthright"), Gokhale, Lala Lajpat Rai, Bhagat Singh, Chandrashekhar Azad, Sarojini Naidu, Rani Lakshmibai.
- **First of many:** first President of INC: W. C. Bonnerjee (1885). First woman President of INC: Annie Besant (1917). First Indian woman President of INC: Sarojini Naidu (1925). First President of India: Dr. Rajendra Prasad. First PM: Jawaharlal Nehru.

World History

- French Revolution 1789 (Bastille, 14 July). American Declaration of Independence 1776. Russian Revolution 1917 (Lenin). Industrial Revolution began in Britain.
- World War I: 1914 to 1918 (Treaty of Versailles, League of Nations). World War II: 1939 to 1945 (Hiroshima 6 Aug and Nagasaki 9 Aug 1945). United Nations: 24 October 1945. Cold War: NATO 1949, Warsaw Pact 1955. USSR dissolved: 1991.

B. GEOGRAPHY

- **Earth:** third planet, only one with life. Rotation: 24 hours (day and night). Revolution: 365¼ days (seasons due to the tilt of 23½°). Equinox: 21 March and 23 September. Summer solstice: 21 June. Winter solstice: 22 December.
- **Atmosphere layers:** Troposphere (weather) → Stratosphere (ozone layer) → Mesosphere → Thermosphere (ionosphere) → Exosphere. Air: 78% nitrogen, 21% oxygen.
- **Rocks:** igneous (granite, basalt), sedimentary (sandstone, limestone), metamorphic (marble, slate). Earthquake: focus (inside), epicentre (surface); seismograph and Richter scale.
- **World:** largest ocean Pacific; deepest point Mariana Trench; highest peak Mount Everest (8,849 m); longest river Nile; largest hot desert Sahara; largest country Russia; largest continent Asia; Suez Canal joins the Mediterranean and Red Sea; Panama Canal joins the Atlantic and Pacific.
- **India:** 28 states and 8 Union Territories. Largest state by area: Rajasthan; smallest: Goa; most populous: Uttar Pradesh. The Tropic of Cancer passes through 8 states (Gujarat, Rajasthan, MP, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Tripura, Mizoram). IST is based on 82°30′ E (near Mirzapur).
- **Himalayas:** Himadri (Greater), Himachal (Lesser), Shiwaliks. Kanchenjunga (8,586 m) is the highest peak in India. Anamudi is the highest peak in South India. Thar Desert: Rajasthan. Chilika: largest coastal lagoon (Odisha).
- **Rivers:** Ganga (longest in India), Brahmaputra, Indus (Jhelum, Chenab, Ravi, Beas, Sutlej), Godavari (longest peninsular), Krishna, Kaveri, Mahanadi flow east to the Bay of Bengal. Narmada and Tapi flow west to the Arabian Sea.
- **Climate:** tropical monsoon. South-West Monsoon June to September. Mawsynram (Meghalaya) has the highest rainfall. **Soils:** alluvial (most fertile), black or regur (cotton), red, laterite, desert.
- **Crops:** Kharif (rice, maize, cotton, jowar, bajra, soybean); Rabi (wheat, barley, gram, mustard, peas). Tea in Assam and Darjeeling, coffee in Karnataka, rubber in Kerala. Green Revolution (wheat and rice, Punjab, Haryana and UP).
- **Minerals and industry:** coal at Jharia (Jharkhand) and Raniganj (West Bengal); iron ore in Odisha, Jharkhand and Chhattisgarh; oil at Mumbai High and Digboi (Assam). Steel plants: Bhilai, Rourkela, Bokaro, Durgapur, Jamshedpur. Largest natural harbour: Mumbai. Dams: Bhakra Nangal (Sutlej), Tehri (highest), Hirakud (Mahanadi), Sardar Sarovar (Narmada).

C. INDIAN POLITY

- **Constitution:** adopted on 26 November 1949; came into force on 26 January 1950. It originally had 395 articles, 22 parts and 8 schedules. The Drafting Committee was chaired by Dr. B. R. Ambedkar. Constituent Assembly president: Dr. Rajendra Prasad.
- **Preamble:** Sovereign, Socialist, Secular, Democratic, Republic. Objectives: Justice, Liberty, Equality, Fraternity. The words Socialist and Secular were added by the 42nd Amendment (1976).
- **Sources:** Government of India Act 1935 (federal scheme, governor), Britain (parliamentary system, rule of law), USA (Fundamental Rights, judicial review), Ireland (Directive Principles), Canada (strong centre), Australia (Concurrent List), Germany (emergency provisions), USSR (Fundamental Duties), South Africa (amendment procedure).

- **Fundamental Rights (Part III, Articles 12 to 35):** Equality (14 to 18), Freedom (19 to 22), Against Exploitation (23, 24), Freedom of Religion (25 to 28), Cultural and Educational Rights (29, 30), Constitutional Remedies (32). Article 21 is the right to life and personal liberty. Article 21A is the right to education (6 to 14 years).
- **Writs:** Habeas Corpus, Mandamus, Prohibition, Certiorari, Quo Warranto. The Supreme Court (Article 32) and High Courts (Article 226) issue them.
- **Directive Principles** (Part IV, Articles 36 to 51) are non-justiciable. **Fundamental Duties** (Article 51A, Part IVA) were added by the 42nd Amendment (now 11 duties).
- **Union Executive:** President (Article 52, elected indirectly by an electoral college, 5-year term, minimum age 35). Vice-President (chairman of the Rajya Sabha). Prime Minister is the head of the Council of Ministers, which is collectively responsible to the Lok Sabha.
- **Parliament:** President + Lok Sabha + Rajya Sabha. Lok Sabha: 543 elected members, 5-year term, minimum age 25, headed by the Speaker. Rajya Sabha: maximum 250 members (12 nominated), permanent house, one-third members retire every 2 years, minimum age 30, chaired by the Vice-President. Money Bill is introduced only in the Lok Sabha.
- **Judiciary:** Supreme Court (Article 124), judges retire at 65. High Court judges retire at 62. There are 25 High Courts. The Supreme Court has original, appellate and advisory jurisdiction, and is the guardian of the Constitution.
- **Emergency:** Article 352 (national), 356 (state or President's Rule), 360 (financial).
- **Constitutional bodies:** Election Commission (Article 324), UPSC (315), Finance Commission (280, every 5 years), Comptroller and Auditor General (148), Attorney General (76).
- **Lists:** Union List (Parliament only), State List, Concurrent List (both). Residuary powers are with the Centre.
- **Important Amendments:** 42nd (1976, mini-Constitution), 44th (1978, property no longer a Fundamental Right), 52nd (1985, anti-defection law), 61st (1988, voting age lowered to 18), 73rd and 74th (1992, Panchayati Raj and Municipalities), 101st (2016, GST).
- **Panchayati Raj:** 73rd Amendment gave constitutional status. Three tiers: Gram Panchayat, Panchayat Samiti, Zila Parishad. First started at Nagaur, Rajasthan (1959).
- **Acts and bodies:** Right to Information Act (2005). National Human Rights Commission (1993). NITI Aayog replaced the Planning Commission (2015).

D. ECONOMY

- India has a **mixed economy**. Sectors: primary (agriculture), secondary (industry), tertiary (services, largest share of GDP).
- **GDP** is the total value of goods and services produced within a country in a year. GNP = GDP + net income from abroad. Per capita income = national income/population.
- **Inflation** is a general rise in prices (measured by CPI and WPI). Deflation is a fall in prices. Stagflation is slow growth with high inflation.
- **Reserve Bank of India:** set up on 1 April 1935, nationalised in 1949, HQ Mumbai. It issues currency (except the one-rupee note), controls credit and regulates banks. Tools: **repo rate** (rate at which RBI lends to banks), reverse repo rate, **CRR** (cash reserve ratio), **SLR** (statutory liquidity ratio).
- **Banks:** SBI is the largest public sector bank. 14 banks were nationalised in 1969 and 6 more in 1980. NABARD (1982) supports rural credit. SIDBI helps small industries.

- **Budget:** presented by the Finance Minister. Revenue deficit = revenue expenditure − revenue receipts. Fiscal deficit = total expenditure − total receipts (excluding borrowing). Financial year: 1 April to 31 March.
- **Taxes:** Direct (income tax, corporate tax). Indirect (GST, customs, excise). GST was launched on 1 July 2017.
- **Five-Year Plans:** started in 1951. First Plan (agriculture), Second Plan (heavy industry, Mahalanobis). The Planning Commission was replaced by NITI Aayog in 2015.
- **1991 reforms:** Liberalisation, Privatisation and Globalisation (LPG), led by P. V. Narasimha Rao and Manmohan Singh.
- **Stock market:** BSE (Sensex, set up in 1875) and NSE (Nifty). SEBI is the regulator.
- **International bodies:** IMF and World Bank (Washington D.C.), WTO (Geneva). **HDI** is published by the UNDP.
- **Demand and supply:** when the price of a good rises, demand falls (law of demand), other things being equal. Unemployment types: disguised (agriculture), seasonal, structural, frictional.

E. GENERAL SCIENCE: QUICK FACTS

Physics	Chemistry	Biology
Unit of force: newton. Work, energy: joule. Power: watt. Pressure: pascal.	Atomic number = protons. Mass number = protons + neutrons.	Cell discovered by Robert Hooke. Mitochondria: powerhouse.
Speed of light: 3×10^8 m/s. Speed of sound in air: about 343 m/s.	pH below 7 acid, above 7 base. Water pH = 7.	Blood groups: Karl Landsteiner. Universal donor: O negative.
Newton's laws: inertia, F = ma, action-reaction.	Baking soda: $NaHCO_3$. Washing soda: Na_2CO_3.	Vitamin C: scurvy. D: rickets. A: night blindness. B_1: beriberi.
Concave mirror: shaving mirror, headlights. Convex mirror: rear-view mirror.	Rusting needs oxygen and moisture. Alloys: brass (Cu + Zn), bronze (Cu + Sn), steel (Fe + C).	Malaria: Anopheles mosquito. Dengue: Aedes. TB: BCG vaccine.
Myopia: concave lens. Hypermetropia: convex lens.	Most electronegative: fluorine. Lightest element: hydrogen. Liquid metal: mercury.	Insulin: pancreas. Thyroxine: thyroid. Adrenaline: adrenal gland.
Fuse is connected in series. Voltmeter in parallel.	Hardest natural substance: diamond. Graphite conducts electricity.	Adult human: 206 bones, 32 teeth, 46 chromosomes.

F. DEFENCE AND CURRENT AFFAIRS

- **President** is the Supreme Commander of the armed forces. The post of **Chief of Defence Staff** was created in 2019.
- **Army Day**: 15 January. **Navy Day**: 4 December. **Air Force Day**: 8 October. **Vijay Diwas**: 16 December (1971 war). **Kargil Vijay Diwas**: 26 July.
- **Gallantry awards:** Param Vir Chakra (highest in war), Maha Vir Chakra, Vir Chakra; Ashoka Chakra (highest in peace), Kirti Chakra, Shaurya Chakra.
- **Academies:** IMA (Dehradun), OTA (Chennai), Indian Naval Academy (Ezhimala, Kerala), Air Force Academy (Dundigal, Hyderabad), NDA (Pune).

- **Field Marshals:** K. M. Cariappa, Sam Manekshaw. DRDO develops Agni, Prithvi, Akash, Nag. HAL builds the Tejas light combat aircraft. INS Vikrant is India's first indigenous aircraft carrier.
- **Space:** ISRO (1969). Aryabhata (1975). Chandrayaan-1 (2008). Mars Orbiter Mission (2013). Chandrayaan-3 landed near the Moon's south pole on 23 August 2023.
- **Honours:** Bharat Ratna is the highest civilian award. Nobel Prizes are announced every October. Arjuna Award and Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna are sports honours.
- **How to cover current affairs:** read a newspaper daily, keep a notebook with Defence, National, International, Sports and Awards, Science and Technology, and revise weekly. Add the latest items yourself, since these notes do not list them.